

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN MONTENEGRO

Complete Community Opposition How-To

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Community action shapes what happens to the rivers, mountains, and coast of Montenegro, and this small country made a promise about nature that no other had made — and then a movement held it to that promise. In 1991, at Žabljak beneath the Durmitor peaks, Montenegro's parliament declared the country the world's first **ecological state**, a commitment later written into the very first article of its Constitution. For years it was largely words. But in 2004, when a hydropower dam at **Buk Bijela** threatened to flood part of the **Tara River Canyon** — one of the deepest canyons on Earth, its water clean enough to drink along its length, protected as part of a UNESCO World Heritage site — Montenegrins turned those words into a weapon. A civil-society campaign, "I don't want a swamp, I want Tara," drafted a citizens' declaration to protect the river, gathered the signatures the law required to put it before parliament, and drew UNESCO's expert missions and the world's attention to a country that called itself ecological but was about to drown its greatest canyon. The dam was stopped. The Tara still runs. The details are worth setting down, because they show how such a fight is won. Montenegro had made its promise in September 1991, when the parliament, meeting at Žabljak, proclaimed the country the world's first ecological state and later wrote that commitment into the very first article of the constitution. The Tara itself, the longest river in the country, had cut one of the deepest canyons on the planet, its walls rising well over a thousand metres, its water so clean it can be drunk along its length; the canyon and the Durmitor massif around it had been a national park since the 1950s and a UNESCO World Heritage site since 1980. When a dam proposed downstream threatened to back water up into that canyon, the campaigners did not merely protest — they wrote a formal declaration for the river's protection, gathered the citizens' signatures the law required to put it before parliament, and summoned UNESCO's expert missions, until a small state that prized both its heritage and its ecological name let the dam go.

The Montenegro story teaches two things about defending rivers and land here — including its honest limits, which this guide states from the outset. The first is the pattern that runs through every guide: not a single silver bullet, but the combination of every lever — the affected community, the documentation, the coalition, the legal and international pressure, and the country's attention — pressed together. The second is distinctly Montenegrin, and it turns the state's own promise against it. **A community can hold the government to its constitutional commitment to be an ecological state, leverage the international protection of UNESCO World Heritage, and use citizens' declarations and civil society to stop a destructive project — even one the state and its neighbours want built.** That power — the ecological-state commitment, the World Heritage shield, the citizens' declaration, and the civil-society coalition — is Montenegro's distinctive lever, and this guide is built around it. What made the Tara campaign work as a model, and what a later campaign can copy, was the way it combined levers that a small country holds in unusual strength. It stood on the constitution's own words, so that the state could be accused not merely of harming a river but of betraying its founding promise; it invoked an international protection, so that a body beyond the state's control was watching; and it turned public feeling into a formal instrument, the citizens' declaration, that the parliament was obliged to consider. Each of those — the constitutional promise, the international shield, the citizens' instrument — is available to a Montenegrin community, and their combination is the template.

But the same story carries honest warnings, and this guide will not hide them. The "ecological state" is a promise the state itself has often **failed to keep** — the very Tara that was saved from the dam was later damaged during the building of a highway, and campaigners say the ideal is too often mocked in practice. The Tara win leaned heavily on **international pressure** that not every fight can summon. And Montenegro is a **small state with real problems of corruption and clientelism**, where powerful interests and foreign investors carry weight. The gap between the promise and the practice is worth facing squarely, because it is the country's central environmental fact. The same Tara that a movement saved from a dam was, years later, visibly scarred during the building of a great highway by a foreign contractor, its banks disturbed and its waters fouled at the construction sites, and campaigners spoke bitterly of an ecological state that existed more on paper than in the riverbed. A community here must therefore treat the ecological-state promise not as a guarantee but as a standard to be enforced — powerful when a movement gives it teeth, hollow when left to the state alone. This guide is written with both truths in view: the real, distinctive power of a movement that wields the ecological-state promise, the World Heritage shield, and the citizens' declaration — and the gap between the promise and the practice, the reliance on outside pressure, and the tilt of a small, clientelist state that qualify it.

Most communities do not know HOW to make that power effective. They face a project and assume "the government and the investors have decided and nothing can be done," and never organise, never document, never invoke the ecological-

state promise or the World Heritage status, never draft the declaration or build the coalition. They generate private loss without a public claim. The gap between a community that saves its river and one that loses it is rarely courage — Montenegrians have shown it. It is method: knowing how to hold the state to its own promise, wield the international protections, gather the citizens, and build the coalition.

This guide shows what actually works — inside the Montenegrin system as it is.

The Strategic Framework

Effective campaigns follow the same underlying pattern, whether the goal is to stop a dam, a mine, a highway, or a coastal development:

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STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION (find the decision, the protections, and the leverage)
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STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION (build proof of the harm and the broken promise)
|
STEP 3: LOCAL OPPOSITION (organise the coalition and the citizens)
|
STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES (the ecological-state law, World Heritage, and the courts)
|
STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY (make it national and international)
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These steps operate **simultaneously, not in sequence**. Documentation feeds the legal case and the public argument at once; the coalition gathers the citizens; a declaration drive or a UNESCO appeal is a headline and a headline builds the coalition. The community that runs all five together, each reinforcing the others, is the one that wins — a project stopped, a protection upheld, a river held. The Tara campaign did exactly this — it documented the harm, drafted the citizens' declaration, invoked the ecological-state promise and the World Heritage status, drew in UNESCO, and carried the fight to the nation.

The Levers That Are Distinctly Strong Here

Every country's system has its own pressure points. Montenegro's give communities a distinctive set:

- **The ecological-state commitment.** Montenegro's **constitutional promise to be an ecological state** is a lever a community can hold the government to, as the Tara campaign did. The value of this promise is that it shifts the moral and rhetorical ground of a fight entirely: a community opposing a project is no longer merely asking the state to weigh nature against development, but holding it to a commitment it made to itself and to the world, so that approving a destructive project becomes an act of self-contradiction the government must publicly justify. Framing a fight as the defence of the ecological-state promise, rather than as one interest among many, draws in citizens who take national pride in that promise and shames a government that would break it.
- **UNESCO World Heritage protection.** **World Heritage status** and UNESCO's monitoring missions are a powerful international shield, as they were for the Tara and Durmitor. The strength of the World Heritage lever lies in its independence from the national government: once a site is inscribed, a body beyond the state's control monitors its condition, can dispatch expert missions to assess a threat, and can publicly report a State Party's failure to protect it — a scrutiny a small country mindful of its standing does not lightly ignore. A community whose fight touches a World Heritage property, or a Biosphere Reserve, holds a channel to that international attention that few other causes can command, and it was exactly this channel that the Tara campaign used to such effect.
- **The citizens' declaration.** A **civil-society declaration**, backed by a citizens' signature campaign, can be put before parliament — a distinctive route the Tara campaign used.
- **International attention and bodies.** **UNESCO, international conservation networks, and the world's attention** amplify a small country's fight and pressure the state.
- **Civil society and expertise.** Montenegro's **environmental organisations, scientists, and legal experts** document, campaign, and litigate.

What This Guide Will Not Pretend

It would be dishonest to promise these levers always hold. The ecological-state promise is **often broken** — the Tara itself was later harmed. The World Heritage shield needs **constant defending**. And a small, clientelist state **tilts toward powerful interests**. This guide takes those limits seriously, names them plainly, and shows you how to use the real, distinctive tools Montenegro offers — the ecological-state promise, the World Heritage status, the citizens' declaration, and the coalition — as Montenegrians used them to save the Tara, and to keep watch over it still.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot pull a lever you cannot see. Before you spend a single week, map who actually decides your project's fate, at which level, and where along that path the decision — or the leverage — is weakest.

The Levels of Decision

A Montenegrin development or energy project runs through several tracks at once, and each is a place to intervene.

The government and the parliament. The **government** approves projects, grants concessions, and sets policy; the **parliament** makes the law — and can be moved by a citizens' declaration, as the Tara campaign moved it. Both are bound, in principle, by the constitutional ecological-state commitment. The parliament deserves particular attention as a target, because Montenegro's system offers a distinctive route to it: a declaration drafted by civil society and backed by a threshold of citizens' signatures can be brought before the legislature as a formal matter it must take up, turning a campaign's demand into a parliamentary question rather than a mere petition to be filed away. Knowing that this route exists, and that the parliament can be obliged to consider a citizens' declaration, changes how a campaign thinks about its goal — not only stopping a permit but winning a binding legislative protection, as the Tara campaign did.

The investors. Foreign and domestic investors — a dam builder, a mining company, a coastal developer, a highway contractor — propose and build the projects.

The protections. Montenegro's **national parks, protected areas, and UNESCO World Heritage and Biosphere status** are real constraints and levers, as they were for the Tara and Durmitor.

The courts. Montenegro's **courts** can review permits and decisions — a real, if constrained, lever in a small state.

Civil society and the public. The **environmental organisations, the communities, and the public** are the force that documents, drafts declarations, campaigns, and draws in the world — the coalition that won the Tara.

The Journey of a Project

A typical project moves from a government or investor proposal, through **concession and environmental permitting**, toward construction — with **civil society, the communities, the courts, UNESCO, and the public** able to document, challenge, and mobilise at any point. **Every one of those stages is a door you can put your foot in.** The distinctive Montenegrin doors are the **ecological-state commitment**, the **World Heritage protection**, the **citizens' declaration**, and the **international pressure**. Find out exactly where your project stands, and, crucially, **whether it touches a protected or World Heritage area, whether it breaks the ecological-state promise, and whether international bodies can be engaged**, because those are often where a project can be stopped.

Follow the Project, the Promise, and the Protection

Behind a project stand a proponent — an investor, the government, or both — and the officials who approve it. Trace who profits, who decided, and — importantly in Montenegro — **whether the project touches a protected area or a World Heritage site, whether it breaks the constitutional ecological-state commitment, whether the community was heard, and what the project does to the river, the canyon, and the endemic life.** Two questions unlock most Montenegrin fights: **Does it violate a protected status, a World Heritage designation, or the ecological-state promise?** and **Can civil society, the citizens, and the international bodies be mobilised?** The protections and the promise are, together, the heart of most Montenegrin campaigns. The two reinforce one another in a way particular to this country: the protected or World Heritage status gives a campaign its legal and international footing, while the ecological-state promise gives it a moral claim on a government that has staked its identity on being green. A campaign that leans only on the protected status may win a technical point without the political force to hold it; one that leans only on the promise may shame the state without a legal hook; the Tara campaign, like the strongest Montenegrin fights, pressed both together — the World Heritage obligation and the ecological-state word.

The Overseers

Finally, know the bodies and forces that can check the deciders, because they are levers too. The **courts**; the **ecological-state commitment and the environmental law**; the **national-park and World Heritage protections**; **UNESCO and the international conservation bodies**; the **environmental organisations and civil society**; the **independent press**; and the **public and the citizens**, whose declaration moved parliament on the Tara. In Montenegro, the **ecological-state promise, the World Heritage shield, and the citizens' declaration**, backed by **international pressure**, are the most distinctive and decisive levers. Each is a separate front, and a project that breaks a protected status, that mocks the ecological-state promise, and that faces a mobilised civil society and UNESCO rarely proceeds untouched — as the Buk Bijela dam did not. You do not have to choose one front: the same documented case — the World

Heritage threat, the broken promise, the harm to the canyon — can go to the courts, to UNESCO, to the parliament through the citizens’ declaration, and to the press all at once, and each front that opens strengthens the others. A Montenegrin campaign’s power comes not from any single lever but from pressing several together — the ecological-state promise before the citizens, the World Heritage obligation before UNESCO, and the flawed permit before the courts — so that a small government facing a mobilised public, an international body, and a legal challenge at once finds a project it can no longer defend, as it found the dam on the Tara.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit months of effort, calibrate honestly. These figures are **directional, not guarantees** — patterns drawn from how Montenegrin and comparable campaigns tend to go, not a controlled study. The decisive variables are whether the project **touches a protected or World Heritage area**, whether it **breaks the ecological-state promise**, whether **civil society and the citizens** can be mobilised, whether **UNESCO and international bodies** can be drawn in, and whether the **courts** can be engaged. Where the project violates a protected status and international bodies engage, Montenegro's levers are real, as the Tara showed; but temper every figure with the honest knowledge that the ecological-state promise is often broken, that the win leaned on international pressure, and that a small, clientelist state tilts toward powerful interests.

Individual Step Success Rates

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	5-10%	months	low	Basis for every other step
Ecological-state / protected-area law	30-55%	months-years	low-moderate	A legal and moral lever; a project contested
World Heritage / UNESCO pressure	40-65%	months-years	low	International shield and monitoring
Citizens' declaration to parliament	30-55%	months	low	A public demand parliament must weigh
Court / permit challenge	25-50%	1-3 years	low-moderate	A permit reviewed or quashed; delay
Civil-society coalition	40-65%	ongoing	low	A broad, expert front
International attention & media	40-65%	ongoing	low	The nation and the world engaged
All steps (protected/WH area, international pressure)	45-70%	months-years	low-moderate	Stopped, protected, or contested
All steps (unprotected land, strong interests)	25-50%	months-years	low-moderate	Delay; partial protection; the record

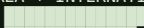
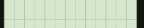
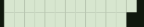
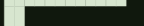
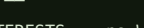
Key insight: every step together beats any single one, and Montenegro's real strengths are distinctive — the **ecological-state commitment**, **UNESCO World Heritage protection**, the **citizens' declaration**, the **civil-society coalition**, and **international attention**. Its constraints are specific: the ecological-state promise is **often unenforced**; the win may lean on **international pressure**; and a small, clientelist state **favours powerful interests**.

A note on cost: organising the coalition, documenting the harm, drafting the declaration, and drawing in UNESCO cost mainly time and commitment, and Montenegro's environmental organisations and scientists make expertise available. The expenditure that most changes outcomes is not money; it is the coalition's breadth and the persistence to hold the state to its promise and draw in the world — exactly what the Tara campaign required.

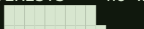
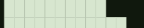
Effectiveness Visualization

SUCCESS PROBABILITY (project stopped, protected, or contested)

PROTECTED / WORLD HERITAGE AREA + INTERNATIONAL PRESSURE + A COALITION:

All steps combined:		45-70%
UNESCO / World Heritage:		40-65%
Civil-society coalition:		40-65%
Ecological-state + citizens:		30-55%
Single step:		5-65%

UNPROTECTED LAND / STRONG INTERESTS -- no WH status, powerful investor:

All steps combined:		25-50%
Courts + coalition:		the levers that remain
Delay / partial protection:		more achievable than a full stop
Single step:		5-50%

How to read this honestly. The levers that most change outcomes in Montenegro are **the World Heritage shield, the civil-society coalition, and international pressure**, backed by the ecological-state promise and the citizens' declaration. The Tara shows the ceiling: a movement invoked the promise and the World Heritage status, drew in UNESCO, and stopped a dam. But the honest floor is real too: the ecological-state promise is often broken, the win leaned on international pressure, and a small clientelist state tilts toward interests. Most Montenegrin fights sit between, and the honest lesson is that the ecological-state promise, the World Heritage protection, the citizens' declaration, and the coalition are powerful levers — decisive when a protected status is at stake and the world engages, weaker on unprotected land against strong interests, where the realistic win is delay, partial protection, and a record. Read the table, then, as a diagnosis of your own position: a campaign defending a World Heritage canyon against a project that flouts the ecological-state promise is in the strong band and can aim to stop it outright, as the Tara campaign did; a campaign over unprotected land against a well-connected investor is in the weaker band and should aim realistically at delay, partial protection, and a record while it looks for a protected status or a flaw to seize on. Knowing which band you are in keeps a campaign both ambitious where it can be and realistic where it must be.

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **The World Heritage shield and international pressure** — Montenegro's most decisive lever; the UNESCO status and monitoring that protected the Tara and Durmitor.
2. **The civil-society coalition and the citizens' declaration** — the broad movement and the citizens' demand that moved parliament on the Tara.
3. **The ecological-state commitment** — the constitutional promise a community holds the government to, a distinctive legal and moral lever.
4. **The courts and the environmental law** — the permit and protected-area challenges that review and can halt a project.
5. **Media and national attention** — the coverage that engages the nation and the world and raises the cost of proceeding.

What Montenegrin Campaigns Actually Show

A few patterns recur. **The promise can be a weapon** — the Tara campaign held the ecological state to its word. **World Heritage protects** — UNESCO's status and missions were decisive. **Citizens can move parliament** — the declaration and its signatures did. **International pressure matters** — a small state heeds its global reputation. **But the promise is often broken** — the Tara was later harmed anyway. The through-line: **hold the state to its ecological-state promise; wield the World Heritage protection; gather the citizens and the coalition; draw in UNESCO and the world; and keep watch — because in Montenegro a movement can hold the state to its own word and stop a destructive project.**

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Every effective campaign begins by finding the exact decision that governs the project — and the leverage the community holds, which in Montenegro is often the protected status, the ecological-state promise, and the reach to UNESCO. Vague opposition goes nowhere; a fight aimed at "the dam that would flood our World Heritage canyon in a country sworn to be an ecological state" is a campaign — the campaign that saved the Tara. Answer five questions.

The Five Core Questions

1. Does it touch a protected or World Heritage area? This is the first Montenegrin question. Does the project threaten a **national park, a protected area, a Biosphere Reserve, or a UNESCO World Heritage site** — because that status is the community's strongest shield and its route to international pressure, as the Tara's World Heritage status

was. This should be the first thing a campaign establishes, because it so often determines the strength of the whole fight. Land or water carrying a World Heritage inscription, a Biosphere designation, or national-park status gives a community a legal and international footing that unprotected ground does not, and even a site not yet formally protected but holding great natural value can sometimes be defended by seeking such a status. Determining early exactly what protection the threatened place holds, and what obligations that protection places on the state, tells a campaign at once how firm a footing it stands on and whether the powerful lever of international scrutiny is open to it.

2. Does it break the ecological-state promise? Does the project **violate the constitutional commitment** to be an ecological state and to base development on sustainability and conservation — the promise a community can hold the government to.

3. What does it do to the river, the canyon, and the endemic life? What **harm** does the project cause — to the river and its clean water, the canyon, the endemic species, the community — and what does the community stand to lose, as the Tara stood to lose its canyon to a swamp? Give particular weight to the river's water and its endemic life, because both carry a force in Montenegro that few arguments match. A river clean enough to drink along its length, as the Tara is, and home to species found in few other places, offers a campaign a cause of visible, tangible value that resonates with a public proud of its natural heritage, and the threat to turn a living, flowing canyon into a still reservoir — a swamp, as the Tara campaign pointedly framed it — is a vivid and mobilising image. Documenting the harm to the clean water and the endemic life, precisely and vividly, connects a local fight to values the whole nation holds.

4. Can civil society, the citizens, and UNESCO be mobilised? Can the **environmental organisations, the citizens, and the international bodies** be united — the citizens for a declaration, UNESCO for its shield, as the Tara campaign united them? The coalition is worth assembling with real deliberation rather than left to form on its own, because its completeness is what has repeatedly proved decisive: a campaign should ask, at the outset, who can supply the scientific evidence, who can draft the declaration and navigate the parliament, who can carry the appeal to UNESCO, and who can reach the national and international public — and then set about recruiting each of those roles. A fight that gathers all of them, as the Tara campaign did, presents the state with a breadth of pressure it cannot easily deflect; one that rests on a single group is far more easily set aside.

5. Who decides, who benefits, and who can be engaged? Which authority and investor are behind it, who profits; and which courts, protections, organisations, UNESCO bodies, press, and public can be engaged. This maps your levers and audiences at once.

A Worked Example

Suppose a dam is proposed that would flood part of a World Heritage canyon, in a country that calls itself an ecological state.

Working the five questions: does it touch a **World Heritage area**? Does it break the **ecological-state promise**? What **harm** to the canyon and the clean water? Can **civil society, the citizens, and UNESCO** be mobilised? And the deciders are the government and the investor, with the courts, the coalition, UNESCO, the press, and the public as the pressure points.

Within a season you have moved from "they will flood the canyon" to a target list: document the harm and the broken promise; draft the citizens' declaration; invoke the World Heritage status and draw in UNESCO; build the coalition; and carry the fight to the nation and the world. That is a campaign, not a complaint — and it draws directly on how the Tara was saved. Notice what the exercise did: it turned a vague alarm about a project into a set of concrete, winnable tasks — establish the World Heritage status, invoke the promise, alert UNESCO, draft the declaration, build the coalition — each tied to a specific lever that Montenegro's system genuinely provides. That reframing, from resignation to a plan built on the country's real strengths, is the difference the five questions make, and the first of them, whether protected or World Heritage land is at stake, often decides how strong a hand the community holds.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Documentation is the foundation everything else stands on. A court, an authority, UNESCO, a journalist, and the public all move on evidence, not indignation — and in Montenegro, the protected status, the broken promise, and the harm are precisely what a campaign turns into pressure, so document them well. Build your file in three layers.

Layer 1: The Project, the Protection, and the Promise

Get the documents the decision rests on. Obtain the **concession, the permits, and the environmental assessment** — and establish the **protected and World Heritage status** of the threatened land and water, because that status is the community's strongest shield and its route to UNESCO. Document how the project **breaks the ecological-state promise** and the law of sustainability and conservation. The gap between what the constitution, the protections, and the law require and what the project would do is where many Montenegrin cases are grounded. The environmental assessment deserves particularly close scrutiny, ideally with expert help, because it is both legally required and technically involved, and it is in its detail that a project's vulnerabilities hide — an impact on the river's flow or water quality understated, a threat to an endemic species ignored, a cumulative effect on the canyon left out, an alternative never seriously weighed. Where a project has been rushed toward approval, as favoured investments often are, the assessment is frequently the weakest link, and a community that reads it carefully rather than assuming it sound often finds the very flaw on which a legal or UNESCO challenge can be built.

Layer 2: The Harm to the River, the Canyon, and the Endemic Life

Document the reality the paper understates, and put the **river, the canyon, and the endemic life** at the centre. Record the **harm** — to the river's clean water, the canyon, the endemic species, the community — that the project would cause, as the Tara campaign documented the threat of a great canyon turned to a swamp. Document what the community **stands to lose**. Photograph and date it. Record **testimony** and gather **expert and scientific evidence**, which Montenegro's scientists and international bodies supply. This is the case that moves the courts, UNESCO, the nation, and the world.

Layer 3: The Protection, the Promise, and the Harm

Finally, document the case. Does the project **violate a protected or World Heritage status**? Does it **break the ecological-state promise**? Is the **harm** to the river, the canyon, and the endemic life real and grave? Each is a separate ground — for the courts, UNESCO, the campaign, and the citizens' declaration — and together they make a case that is hard to wave away. This is the layer that most often decides Montenegrin fights, because here a project sold as development is revealed to violate a World Heritage protection, to break the state's own constitutional promise, and to threaten a great river and canyon — exactly the case that saved the Tara. The strength of assembling all three grounds together — the protected or World Heritage status, the broken promise, and the harm — is that they serve different fronts and reinforce one another: the protected status and the flawed process are what a court and UNESCO can act on, the harm to the canyon and the clean water is what moves the public and the scientists, and the broken ecological-state promise is what shames the government before its citizens. A campaign that documents only the harm may move hearts without a legal footing; one that documents only the legal flaw may win a point without the public behind it; the campaigns that prevail in Montenegro, as the Tara campaign did, build all three and press them together.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

This is the practical companion to Step 2: the specific records that decide Montenegrin cases, and where to obtain them. You will not need every item; you will need the few that establish the protected status, the broken promise, and the harm.

The Project, the Protection, and the Paper Trail

- **The concession and the permits** — how the project was authorised, and by which authority.
- **The environmental assessment** — the study behind the permit, and often the most vulnerable to challenge.
- **The protected and World Heritage status** — the national-park, Biosphere, and UNESCO designations, the community's strongest shield.
- **The ecological-state and sustainability law** — the constitutional promise and the statutes that bind development to conservation.
- **The investor and the beneficiaries** — who profits, and where the project sits in policy.

How to Get Them

The permits, concessions, and assessments are matters of record, obtainable from the authorities and through access-to-information requests; the protected and World Heritage status through the national-park authorities and UNESCO's own documentation; the ecological-state and sustainability law through the constitution and statutes. Lean on **allies**: Montenegro's environmental organisations, the scientists and legal experts who drafted the Tara declaration, and — distinctively — the **UNESCO and international conservation bodies** whose missions and reports carry real weight. Move promptly: obtaining the assessment and establishing the World Heritage status early lets you draw in UNESCO and

challenge the project before it hardens, as the Tara campaign drew in UNESCO's missions while the decision was still open. Timing matters here and repays acting on early: the World Heritage status, the assessment, and the terms of the concession are most useful obtained and publicised while the decision is still open and construction has not begun, because a project is far easier to stop before money is committed and ground is broken, and UNESCO's scrutiny carries most weight while a threat can still be averted rather than merely lamented. The Tara campaign moved to alert the international bodies and rally the citizens while the dam was still a proposal; a community that acts with the same speed, securing the documents and opening the international channels while the ground is still whole, gives itself by far the best chance.

The Ground Evidence

- **The harm** — to the river, the canyon, the clean water, the endemic species, dated and documented.
- **The protected and World Heritage status** — the designations and what they forbid.
- **The broken promise** — how the project violates the ecological-state commitment.
- **The expert and international evidence** — the scientific studies and the UNESCO/IUCN assessments.
- **Testimony** — from the community and those who know the river and the canyon.

Organise It So It Persuades

Keep a **master timeline** of the concession, the permit, the protected status, the harm, and every step of the fight — the spine of any case, declaration, or UNESCO appeal. Keep a **document index** so any fact can be sourced in seconds. And keep an **argument bank** (developed in a later section) that pairs each fact with what it proves, to whom. A well-ordered file is not bureaucracy; it is what lets a villager, a scientist, a lawyer, a journalist, a UNESCO expert, and a member of parliament all see the same clear picture fast, and it guards against the campaign's own worst enemy, a claim that cannot be sourced when the investor or the authority pushes back. In a country where the World Heritage status and the ecological-state promise decide, the community with the better-kept file — above all the clearest proof of the protected status and the broken promise — is very often the one that wins, as the Tara campaign won.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION — HOW TO ORGANISE THE COALITION AND THE CITIZENS

Evidence and protections do not win on their own. An organised coalition, and the citizens, do — and in Montenegro, the Tara campaign proved that civil society, scientists, and the citizens, backed by UNESCO, can hold the state to its promise and stop a dam. A campaign's strength here is that coalition: broad, expert, rooted in the community, and reaching to the citizens and the world.

Phase 1: The Core and the Community

Start with a committed core rooted in the **affected community** and the **environmental organisations** whose expertise anchors the fight, as the NGO that drafted the Tara declaration anchored it. Assign roles — documentation, legal, the citizens' declaration and signatures, media, and UNESCO and international liaison. Agree on the goal — the project stopped, the protection upheld, the river held — and on what the community will and will not accept. Draw on Montenegro's environmental infrastructure, small but capable, and its scientists and legal experts.

Phase 2: The Broad Coalition

Then widen deliberately. Bring in the **affected communities**; the **environmental organisations and scientists**, who bring the expertise and drafted the Tara declaration; the **legal experts**, who craft the declaration and the challenge; the **citizens**, whose signatures put the declaration before parliament; the **UNESCO and international conservation bodies**, whose missions and reports are a distinctive Montenegrin lever; and the **wider public and the press**. The Tara campaign drew its power from exactly this breadth — communities, scientists, legal experts, citizens, and UNESCO — which is precisely the spread a winning Montenegrin campaign needs. The distinctive element in that coalition is the pairing of local civil society with international bodies, and it is worth building deliberately: the domestic organisations and scientists supply the evidence and the citizens' signatures, while UNESCO and the international conservation networks supply a scrutiny the government cannot dismiss as merely domestic opposition. When a small state faces both a mobilised citizenry demanding it keep its ecological promise and an international body reporting on its stewardship of a World Heritage site, it confronts a combination that is very hard to override, which is why the Tara campaign reached for both at once.

A worked coalition example. Facing a dam in a World Heritage canyon, the community forms the base; the environmental organisations and scientists bring the evidence; the legal experts draft the citizens' declaration; the citizens sign it to parliament; UNESCO's missions add the international shield; and the press carries it to the nation. No single group could carry it; together they cover the ground, the science, the law, the citizens, and the world — the model that saved the Tara. What is worth drawing from that model is how each element supplied what the others lacked: the community brought the local standing of those who would bear the harm, the scientists the authority to say exactly what would be lost, the legal experts the craft to turn feeling into a declaration and a challenge, the citizens the signatures that gave the declaration its force, and the international bodies the scrutiny the state could not dismiss. A community beginning a fight should honestly assess which of these it already holds and which it must recruit, because it is the completeness of the coalition, not the intensity of any single part, that has repeatedly proved decisive in Montenegro.

Phase 3: Sustaining It

Campaigns die of burnout, not defeat — and a Montenegrin fight can run through a long process and a longer watch, for the ecological-state promise must be defended again and again. Meet on a rhythm. Give people concrete tasks. Mark small wins — the assessment obtained, the declaration drafted, the signatures gathered, a UNESCO mission secured, a wave of coverage. Keep the coalition broad and the citizens engaged, and guard against the **division and the co-optation** — the promise of jobs or investment, the pressure on a small community, the wearing-down of a long fight — that powerful interests will use, and against the **complacency** of assuming the ecological-state promise will protect the land on its own. This complacency is a particular danger in a country that has told itself for decades that it is an ecological state, because the very existence of the promise can lull citizens into assuming the land is already safe, that surely the state that calls itself green will not permit its own great river to be harmed. The later damage to the Tara during the highway's construction is the standing rebuke to that assumption, and a campaign's constant task is to remind people that the promise protects nothing on its own — that it is only ever as strong as the citizens willing to hold the state to it.

Phase 4: The Citizens' Declaration and the International Appeal

Here is Montenegro's distinctive strength, on two levels. First, **gather the citizens**: draft a **declaration to protect the river or the land**, as the Tara campaign did, and gather the **signatures the law requires** to put it before parliament, turning public feeling into a formal demand the parliament must weigh. Second, **appeal to the world**: invoke the **World Heritage status** and call in **UNESCO's monitoring missions and reports**, the distinctive international shield that pressures a small state mindful of its global standing, as UNESCO's missions pressured Montenegro over the Tara. Keep the campaign **disciplined, factual, and broad**, because a credible, well-evidenced movement backed by citizens and UNESCO is what moves the government, and the investor and the state will seize on any exaggeration. Credibility is a particular asset in a Montenegrin campaign, because much of its power comes from the moral high ground of holding the state to its own promise and from the trust of international bodies like UNESCO, both of which a careless overstatement would squander. A campaign should therefore hold itself to a strict accuracy, letting the documented facts — the World Heritage status, the broken promise, the harm to the canyon — carry the argument, because in a fight waged before the citizens and the world a reputation for telling the exact truth is worth more than any rhetorical flourish, and an exaggeration once exposed can undo a campaign's standing with the very bodies whose support it needs. The point is not spectacle; it is to demonstrate — to the government, the investor, and the world — that the citizens demand protection and the ecological state is being watched, as it was watched over the Tara.

STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES — THE ECOLOGICAL-STATE LAW, WORLD HERITAGE, AND THE COURTS

Montenegro's constitutional ecological-state commitment, its World Heritage protections, and its courts are a real, if imperfect, legal toolkit — and the distinctive instruments are the ecological-state promise and the World Heritage shield, which the Tara campaign wielded to great effect. You do not need a courtroom victory to win: a protection upheld, a UNESCO intervention, a citizens' declaration adopted, or a project abandoned under legal and international pressure can each be a real victory. Engage lawyers, scientists, and UNESCO early — but understand the tools.

The Ecological-State Commitment and the Protections

The first and most distinctive lever is the **ecological-state commitment and the protections**. Montenegro's **constitution declares it an ecological state**, binding development to sustainability and conservation, and its **national parks, protected areas, and World Heritage and Biosphere status** are real legal constraints. Establish that the project violates these, and hold the state to its own promise; the ecological-state commitment and the protected status

are the community's strongest legal and moral ground, as they were for the Tara.

World Heritage and UNESCO

The second lever, distinctive to Montenegro's great sites, is **World Heritage and UNESCO**. A project threatening a **World Heritage site** — as the Buk Bijela dam threatened Durmitor and the Tara — triggers **UNESCO's monitoring, its expert missions, and its reports**, which carry real international weight and pressure a state mindful of its standing and its heritage. Invoke the World Heritage status, alert the World Heritage Centre, and seek the expert missions, as the Tara campaign did — this international shield is one of Montenegro's most powerful levers. A campaign should understand how to use this shield concretely rather than vaguely: alert the World Heritage Centre in writing with documented evidence of the threat, request that the property's state of conservation be examined and that an expert mission be sent, and press for the threat to be raised with the State Party and, if necessary, noted in the Committee's decisions — each of which creates a formal international record and a point of pressure. It was precisely this sequence of international scrutiny, culminating in expert missions and reports, that helped ensure the Buk Bijela dam threatening the Tara was set aside.

The Courts and the Citizens' Declaration

The third lever is the **courts and the citizens' declaration**. Montenegro's **courts** can review the legality of permits and decisions, a real if constrained tool; and the **citizens' declaration**, backed by the signatures the law requires, puts a formal demand before **parliament**, a distinctive route to a binding protection, as the Tara declaration was. Use the courts to challenge a flawed permit, and the declaration to win a parliamentary protection. The two work best in combination rather than as alternatives: a court challenge can suspend or overturn a permit while the slower political work proceeds, and a citizens' declaration adopted by parliament can secure a lasting protection that no single permit decision can undo. A campaign that pursues only litigation may win a temporary halt that a re-issued permit later defeats; one that pursues only the declaration may find the project built before parliament acts. The Tara campaign's strength lay in combining the legal and international pressure that bought time with the citizens' declaration that sought a durable protection.

Where to Turn and With Whom

Protected-status and permit challenges go through the **authorities and the courts**; the World Heritage lever through **UNESCO and its World Heritage Centre**; the citizens' declaration through the **parliament**. Get help early: Montenegro's environmental organisations, scientists, and legal experts — those who drafted the Tara declaration — know the law, the protections, and the routes, and the international bodies amplify them. Reaching these allies early rather than late can shape the whole course of a fight, because the earliest steps — alerting UNESCO while a threat is still emerging, drafting the declaration before positions harden, framing the legal challenge on the strongest ground — often determine whether a campaign can succeed at all, and Montenegro's environmental organisations and scientists have fought these battles before and know how to open the international channels. A community that brings them in at the first sign of a threat, rather than after a concession has been signed, gives itself the benefit of that hard-won experience when it matters most. Help engaged early — before a project hardens — is worth far more than help sought after, and in Montenegro the strongest strategy marries the **ecological-state promise and the protected status** to the **World Heritage shield** and the **citizens' declaration**, with the courts in support.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

You have a file of evidence. Now you must turn it into arguments — because the same fact persuades a court, an authority, UNESCO, a journalist, and the public in different ways. Learning to translate your evidence for each audience is what lets a community reach every lever at once.

One Fact, Many Arguments

Take a single documented fact — say, that a dam would flood part of a World Heritage canyon and destroy the clean water and endemic life of a river, in a country whose constitution declares it an ecological state. That one fact becomes:

- **A constitutional argument:** the project breaks the ecological-state promise written into the constitution — the case that holds the government to its word.
- **A World Heritage argument:** the project threatens a UNESCO World Heritage site — the ground that triggers international monitoring and pressure.
- **A legal argument:** the project violates the protected status and the conservation law — the case before the courts.
- **A public argument:** they would drown our canyon and our clean river in a country that calls itself ecological — the

case that unites the citizens.

- **A scientific argument:** the project would destroy an irreplaceable canyon and its endemic life — the case that persuades the experts and UNESCO.

Same fact, five arguments, five audiences. Go through your strongest facts and, for each, ask what it proves to each audience. That table is your campaign's argument bank — and in Montenegro the arguments that most often decide things are the **World Heritage** one, because it draws in UNESCO, and the **broken-promise** one, because it shames the ecological state before its citizens and the world. Keep the arguments anchored to the same documented facts, so a claim made to a reporter can be backed in the record and a claim made to UNESCO can be proven by the science; consistency across audiences is itself persuasive.

Match the Argument to the Audience

The courts want the violation of the protected status and the law framed against the statutes, with the documents that prove it.

The government and parliament respond to the broken ecological-state promise, the citizens' declaration, and the international pressure.

UNESCO responds to the threat to the World Heritage site, framed against the conservation obligations, with the scientific evidence.

Journalists need a specific, vivid story with a hook: a dam that would drown one of the deepest canyons on Earth in a country sworn to be an ecological state.

The public and the citizens need the argument simple and true: our canyon, our clean river, our heritage, threatened despite the promise — sign the declaration.

The scientists and conservation bodies respond to the threat to the endemic life and the irreplaceable canyon.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY — HOW PRESS COVERAGE SHIFTS OUTCOMES

Media is not vanity; it is a lever — and in Montenegro, where the ecological-state promise and the world's attention decide, coverage that shames the state before its citizens and the world is among the most powerful levers of all. Coverage draws in UNESCO, shifts opinion, and pressures the government. The Tara campaign succeeded in large part because it made a national and international story of a country that called itself ecological but was about to drown its greatest canyon.

Build the Story

Reporters and the public need specifics: a named place, a documented wrong, and a natural stake. "A project is controversial" is not a story; "a dam would flood one of the deepest canyons on Earth and drown a river clean enough to drink, in the world's first ecological state" is — the story that saved the Tara. Lead with your strongest verified facts — the World Heritage status, the broken promise, the harm to the canyon and the clean water — and offer a human and natural voice: a villager, a scientist, the threatened canyon. In Montenegro the story of a great river and a broken promise is one that resonates at home and abroad.

Reach the Right Outlets

Work outward in rings. **Local and community voices** first. Then the **national outlets** — because a threat to a national treasure and the ecological-state promise is a national story. Then, crucially, the **international and UNESCO ring** — the international conservation press and networks, and UNESCO itself — because for a small country mindful of its standing, international attention to a World Heritage site is decisive, as it was for the Tara. Feed each ring what it needs, and let coverage in one pull in the next. The **international ring is especially powerful** in Montenegro, because a small state heeds its global reputation and its World Heritage obligations. This is a lever a campaign should use with some deliberateness, because a country that has built part of its identity and its tourism on being an unspoiled, ecological state is unusually sensitive to international coverage that portrays it as betraying that image. A story that reaches the international press — a government about to drown a world-class canyon in the world's first ecological state — threatens something the state values highly, its reputation and its brand, and that reputational stake can move a government that a purely domestic protest might not, as the international attention to the Tara helped move Montenegro.

Sustain It, and Keep It True

A single article changes little; a drumbeat changes decisions — and a Montenegrin fight can run through a long process and a longer watch. Plan a sequence — the threat, the harm, the broken promise, the citizens' declaration, the UNESCO mission, the government's retreat — so there is always a next hook, and build your own clear record so the story reaches the nation and the world and endures. Keep messaging disciplined, accurate, and consistent; the investor and the authorities will seize on any exaggeration, and a credible, well-evidenced campaign is what moves a government mindful of its reputation. Verified, specific, World-Heritage-and-broken-promise-centred, and relentless — that is the coverage that shifts outcomes here, and that helped save the Tara.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Written communications are how you request, object, create a record, and reach the bodies that can act — the authorities, the investors, the courts, UNESCO, and the press. Each does double duty: it asks for something and it documents that you asked. Keep copies of everything, and send important items so that receipt is provable. Below are adaptable templates for the situations you will meet most often. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the protected status, the promise, and the harm.

8A. Request for Information (Access to Information)

To: the relevant authority **Subject:** Request for information on [project] near [protected/World Heritage area]

Under the access-to-information law, we, [community/organisation], request the **concession, the permits, the environmental assessment, and all documents** relating to [project] affecting [protected/World Heritage area]. This project affects a protected area and the public interest, and the public has a right to know. Please provide the documents within the statutory period.

8B. Objection Invoking the Ecological-State Promise

To: the government / the permitting authority **Subject:** Objection to [project] — a breach of the ecological-state commitment

We, [community/organisation], object to [project]. It threatens [protected/World Heritage area], harms [the river / the canyon / the endemic life], and **breaks the constitutional commitment** to an ecological state and to development based on conservation. We demand that it be **refused or halted**, and we reserve our right to the courts, the citizens' declaration, and an appeal to UNESCO.

8C. Appeal to UNESCO / the World Heritage Centre

To: the UNESCO World Heritage Centre **Subject:** Threat to the World Heritage property of [site] from [project]

We write to alert you that [project] threatens the World Heritage property of [site]: it would [flood the canyon / harm the river / damage the site], as documented and attached. We request that the World Heritage Centre **examine the threat, send an expert mission, and address it with the State Party**, as was done for the Tara and Durmitor.

8D. Citizens' Declaration to Parliament

To: the Parliament of Montenegro **Subject:** Citizens' declaration for the protection of [river/area]

We, the undersigned citizens of Montenegro, submit this **Declaration for the protection of [river/area]**, and call on Parliament to adopt it and to protect [river/area] from [project]. In keeping with Montenegro's constitutional commitment to be an ecological state, we ask that this natural treasure be safeguarded for present and future generations. [Signatures attached.]

8E. Court Challenge (with a Lawyer)

To: the court (via counsel) **Subject:** Challenge to the permit for [project]

On behalf of [community/organisation], we challenge the permit for [project] as **unlawful**: it violates [the protected/World Heritage status], the conservation law, and the ecological-state commitment, and rests on a **flawed assessment**. We

seek its **annulment** and the halting of works, and attach the record demonstrating the protected status and the flaws.

8F. Instructing a Lawyer / Environmental Organisation

To: an environmental organisation / public-interest lawyer **Subject:** [Project] — protected status, the promise, and the challenge

We are opposing [project] affecting [protected/World Heritage area]. We attach the permits, the protected-status documents, and our evidence of harm, and seek advice on **the protected-area and permit challenge, the citizens' declaration, and the UNESCO appeal**. Please advise on the strongest ground and the deadlines.

8G. Email to a Reporter (National or International)

To: [journalist] **Subject:** Story tip: [specific finding] — [the river / the canyon / the project]

I follow your coverage of [beat]. We have something the public should know, with a clear hook: [documents] show [quantified finding — e.g. "a dam would flood one of the deepest canyons on Earth and a river clean enough to drink, in the world's first ecological state"]. It echoes the Tara. I can share the file and connect you with a scientist and a villager. Could we talk this week?

8H. Public Statement

To: the public and the authorities **Subject:** [Community/organisation] opposes [project]

We, [community/organisation], oppose [project], which would **harm [protected/World Heritage area]**, threaten [the river / the canyon / the endemic life], and **break Montenegro's promise** to be an ecological state. As Montenegrins saved the Tara, we will use the ecological-state commitment, the World Heritage protection, the citizens' declaration, and the courts to stop it. We call on the government to keep its own promise, and we will not relent.

Using the Templates Well

Send important communications so that receipt is provable, and log every one in your timeline — the record of a request, an objection, a UNESCO appeal, or a declaration is itself evidence, and exactly what the authorities, the courts, UNESCO, and the public will heed. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the protected status, the promise, and the harm; attach your evidence; and route them, where you can, through the coalition, the environmental organisations, your lawyers, UNESCO, and the press. The reply, or the decision, becomes part of your record, and in Montenegro that record feeds the levers that matter most: the ecological-state promise, the World Heritage shield, the citizens' declaration, and the international pressure.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Not everyone can run a long campaign. With a few hours a week you can still do real damage to a bad project. In rough order of impact for the effort:

- 1. Establish the protected and World Heritage status.** Find out whether the project touches a protected area, a Biosphere Reserve, or a World Heritage site (Step 1, Step 2).
- 2. Invoke the ecological-state promise.** Frame the project as a breach of the constitutional commitment, and object on that ground (8B).
- 3. Alert UNESCO.** If a World Heritage site is threatened, alert the World Heritage Centre and seek a mission (8C).
- 4. Draft the citizens' declaration.** With legal help, draft a declaration and begin gathering the signatures the law requires (8D).
- 5. Reach the environmental organisations.** Connect with Montenegro's environmental groups and scientists (8F).
- 6. Move the public and the press.** Take the broken promise and the harm to the nation and the world (Step 5, 8G).
- 7. Threaten the legal ground.** With a lawyer, challenge a project that violates a protected status or a flawed permit

(8E).

Do only the first three and you will have established the protected status, invoked the promise, and alerted UNESCO — the foundation of a Montenegrin defence. Then come back and read the rest. Even the shortest version has a spine: establish the status, invoke the promise, alert UNESCO.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Montenegro's system is tilted in specific ways you must understand, so you neither waste effort nor miss the levers that work.

Where the Tilt Shows

The tilt here is real, and the gap between the promise and the practice is its clearest sign. The **ecological-state commitment is often unenforced** — the very Tara that was saved from a dam was later damaged during a highway's construction, and campaigners say the ideal is too often mocked. Montenegro is a **small state** where **corruption and clientelism** shape decisions, and **powerful investors and foreign money** — for dams, mines, highways, and coastal resorts — carry political weight. **Institutions can be weak or captured**, and an assessment can be bent toward a favoured project. Where these tilts bite, a campaign that assumes the ecological-state promise will protect the land on its own, or that a World Heritage status is untouchable, will be disappointed — as the damage to the Tara showed.

What Still Works — And Some Is Distinctive

The decisive point is that even against this tilt, real levers remain.

The ecological-state promise still shames. Even unenforced, the constitutional commitment is a standard a community can hold the state to before its citizens and the world.

World Heritage still protects. UNESCO's status, missions, and reports are a real international constraint, as they were for the Tara.

The citizens' declaration still moves parliament. A declaration backed by signatures is a formal demand parliament must weigh, as the Tara declaration was.

International pressure still tells. A small state mindful of its reputation heeds UNESCO and the world.

Civil society still organises. Montenegro's environmental organisations and scientists remain a capable, expert force.

The Honest Frame

So the honest frame for Montenegro is realistic but far from hopeless: the ecological-state promise is often broken, the state is small and clientelist, and powerful interests tilt the field, but the promise, the World Heritage shield, the citizens' declaration, and international pressure give a determined coalition real levers. So diagnose your fight honestly: establish the **protected and World Heritage status**; invoke the **ecological-state promise**; draft the **citizens' declaration**; draw in **UNESCO and the world**; build the **coalition**; and keep watch, because a saved river can still be harmed. Do not assume the promise will protect the land on its own; the Tara was saved because a movement made the ecological state keep its word, and must be watched because the state does not always keep it.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO IS CAPTURED

Montenegro has real and long-documented concerns about corruption, clientelism, and the influence of powerful investors and foreign money, so this section matters. When a project is driven not by the public interest but by the connected, or by foreign money that captures a decision, your strategy includes exposing that.

How to Tell

Look for the signatures of capture. A **concession or permit granted against the ecological-state promise** and the protected status; **foreign money** — for a dam, a highway, a resort — that shapes a decision; an **assessment bent**

toward a favoured project; **institutions deferring** to a powerful investor; and **benefits to the connected** while the community and the environment bear the harm, as with the damage done to the Tara during a foreign-built highway. Trace the concession and the money: who granted it, who profits, whether the public interest and the protected land were sacrificed. In Montenegro, a project that violates the ecological-state promise for a powerful investor is often not a mere policy choice but an arrangement that serves the connected.

Who Can Be Captured — and Who Is Harder

Be clear-eyed about where capture reaches. **Parts of the government and the institutions** can be captured by powerful investors and foreign money. But some forces are far harder to capture, and they are your targets: the **courts**, which can review a decision; **UNESCO and the international bodies**, beyond the state's control; the **environmental organisations and scientists**; the **independent press**; and the **citizens**, whose declaration and vote carry weight. Capture thrives on the public's inattention and the promise's emptiness; your task is to fill the promise with meaning, document the capture, and bring it to the courts, UNESCO, and the citizens.

What to Do

Do not assume a captured project cannot be stopped. Instead, **document the capture precisely** — how the concession was granted against the promise, who benefits, what protected land was sacrificed — and take it to the forces that can act: the **courts**, to review the decision; **UNESCO**, to bring international pressure; the **independent press and international networks**, to expose it; and the **citizens**, through the declaration. Pair the exposure with the ecological-state and World Heritage arguments, so the impropriety and the broken promise arrive together. In Montenegro, exposing how a project captured a decision against the ecological-state promise, and rousing the citizens and UNESCO, is often the way to stop it — as the pressure of citizens and UNESCO helped save the Tara. There is a wider significance to winning such a fight that a community should hold onto: every project stopped in the name of the ecological-state promise, and every World Heritage site successfully defended, gives that promise more meaning and warns the next investor and the next official that the commitment is not merely decorative. In a country where the promise is too often empty, each enforced instance fills it a little more, and a community that fights and wins does not only save its own river but strengthens the standard that protects them all — turning a paper commitment, case by case, into a real constraint. It is worth adding that the exposure of capture is itself a service to the ecological-state promise, because each arrangement dragged into the light — each concession shown to have been granted against the country's own conservation commitment for the benefit of the connected — makes the next such arrangement harder to conceal, and gradually raises the political cost of treating the promise as empty. A campaign that documents and publicises how a decision was captured is not only fighting one project but defending the integrity of the commitment on which every future fight will stand.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

The five steps win when they run together. Here is how they fit across the life of a fight — which in Montenegro turns on the ecological-state promise, the World Heritage shield, and the citizens' declaration.

Early (Months 0-6): The Status, the Promise, and the Coalition

Pin down the project and the deciding authority (Step 1); establish the **protected and World Heritage status** and document the **harm** and the **broken promise** (Step 2). Build the **coalition** with the environmental organisations, scientists, and legal experts (Step 3). Move at once on what is decisive: **object on the ecological-state ground** (8B); **alert UNESCO** (8C); begin the **citizens' declaration** (8D); and reach **lawyers and scientists** early (8F). This phase lays the foundation, and in Montenegro the World Heritage status, the invoked promise, and the coalition established here are what win.

Middle (Months 3-24): Declare, Appeal, and Challenge

Sustain the coalition and gather the **citizens' signatures** (Step 3). Turn your evidence into arguments for each audience (Turning Evidence). Press the **UNESCO appeal** and the **court challenge** (Step 4). Build the media drumbeat from local to national to international (Step 5). Each front feeds the others. Do the time-critical things first — alerting UNESCO and gathering the signatures before the project hardens — because those chances do not return.

Later (Months 6-36+): The Protection, and the Watch

Pursue the decisive outcome — the **project abandoned, the protection upheld, the river held** — and then keep watch, because, as the later damage to the Tara showed, a saved river can still be harmed, and the ecological-state promise must be defended again and again. Judge success honestly. Sometimes it is a project stopped and a protection won, as with the Tara dam. Sometimes it is a partial protection, won and then guarded year after year. Both are victories worth the fight. And even a partial protection compounds over time in a country still learning to honour its promise: a river spared today gains defenders and a precedent, a citizens' declaration once adopted becomes a standard the next project must clear, and a World Heritage obligation invoked once is more readily invoked again. A campaign should value what it can win now, not only for its own river but for the way each enforced protection and each honoured promise strengthens the ecological state the Tara campaign made, for a moment, real.

The Shape of a Campaign

MONTHS 0-6	Establish protected/WH status + harm Invoke the promise Alert UNESCO Build the coalition Begin the declaration
MONTHS 3-24	Gather signatures UNESCO appeal Court challenge Media
MONTHS 6-36+	Project abandoned / protection upheld / river held Keep watch, for the promise is often broken

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Montenegro gives communities a genuinely powerful — and distinctive — set of tools, and the honest measure of this guide is how squarely it faces both their strength and their limits.

The strengths are real and distinctive. The **ecological-state commitment**, written into the constitution, is a promise a community can hold the government to, as the Tara campaign did. **UNESCO World Heritage status** and its monitoring missions are a powerful international shield, as they were for Durmitor and the Tara. The **citizens' declaration**, backed by the signatures the law requires, can move parliament to protect a river. And a capable **civil society**, with its scientists and legal experts, can document, campaign, and litigate. These are the tools that let Montenegrins hold the world's first ecological state to its word and save one of the deepest canyons on Earth. They are, notably, tools that depend on a promise, a protection, and an organised citizenry rather than on wealth or power, which is why a small movement could prevail over a dam its own government and its neighbours had planned — and why, used with the same resolve, they remain available to communities across the country wherever a protected place or the ecological-state promise is at stake.

The limits are just as real, and this guide names them. The ecological-state promise is **often broken** — the saved Tara was later harmed. The win **leaned on international pressure** that not every fight can summon. And a small, clientelist state **tilts toward powerful interests and foreign money**. No guide should pretend these away; in Montenegro, the art is to hold the state to its promise, to wield the World Heritage shield, to gather the citizens, and to keep watch over a win that the state itself may not defend.

So the realistic promise is this: **establish the protected and World Heritage status; invoke the ecological-state promise; draft the citizens' declaration; draw in UNESCO and the world; build the coalition; and keep watch — running all of it together**. Do that, and where a protected or World Heritage status is at stake and the world engages, you can stop a project and win a protection, as the Tara campaign did; where the promise is broken and the interests strong, you can still win delay, partial protection, and a record, and keep fighting. Do it as the Tara campaign did — Montenegrins who held the ecological state to its word, gathered the citizens, drew in UNESCO, and saved their great river.

A last word on the promise and the watch. Montenegro's lesson is that a state's own promise can be turned into a weapon in the hands of its citizens — that a country that calls itself an ecological state can be held to that word, and made to spare a canyon it was about to drown — but that the promise is only as strong as the movement that enforces it, and must be watched, because the state does not always keep it. The powerful count on your resignation and on the emptiness of the promise. Their advantage is the clientelism, the foreign money, and the gap between the word and the deed. Yours is a constitution that calls the country ecological, a World Heritage shield, a citizens' declaration, a capable civil society, the world's attention, and the proven fact that the Tara was saved. Play to that. Keep the record and the proof of the protected status and the broken promise, keep the coalition broad and the citizens gathered, wield the promise and the World Heritage shield, and treat every declaration, every UNESCO mission, every filing, and every protected river held as a stone in a wall that even the clientelism cannot easily climb.

The tools are here, and Montenegro itself proved them: a movement that held the world's first ecological state to its constitutional word, drafted a citizens' declaration, drew in UNESCO's missions, and stopped a dam that would have drowned one of the deepest canyons on Earth. What decides the outcome, in the end, is the coalition's breadth, the World Heritage shield, the citizens' declaration, the international pressure, and the vigilance to defend a win — and those a determined community can summon. Begin today, begin with the protected status and the promise and the declaration,

and build from there. Communities before you have saved a great river and held the state to its word — a dam stopped, a promise enforced, a canyon held. They did it with a coalition, a citizens' declaration, and the World Heritage shield, against a government and its neighbours who had planned the dam, and at times against a state that treated its own promise as decoration — which is exactly why your own community's effort, added to theirs, is neither hopeless nor unimportant. What the Tara campaign won can be won again. So can yours. A movement that held its state to the promise written in its constitution, that gathered the citizens' signatures and summoned the world's attention, and that would not let a great canyon be drowned, has shown what an organised citizenry can do with the distinctive tools of the world's first ecological state; the promise, the World Heritage shield, the citizens' declaration, the coalition, and the world's attention are the method, and the proof that even a planned dam can be turned back is now yours to take up and use.